

Figure 7: KDE desktop right-click menu has a Konsole shortcut

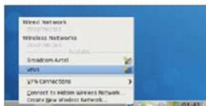


Figure 8: What's GNOME's NetworkManager doing in KDE?



Figure 9: Qt-based NetworkManager available in openSUSE

introducing Echo into the distro as the default icon theme. This will definitely make Fedora stand out from the rest.

As for the apps, they are the typical defaults, and nothing much to add here. It's the updated stack and, like I mentioned earlier: GNote has replaced Tomboy and Empathy has replaced Pidgin.

That's all in the report here. Oh, did I mention PackageKit appears to work more quickly in this release. The usual querying and 'waiting in queue' seemed to occur a lot less now.

Anyway, many of you launch PackageKit to install those missing multimedia codes. Well, here's a nice guide to configure the support: <http://oojah.fishbowl42.com/blog1.php/2009/12/01/multimedia-codesc-flash-and-encrypted-dvds-on-fedora-12>.

Talking about multimedia, I guess

it's better to install Omega, the Fedora Remix I mentioned earlier, instead.

By the way, I found switching to proprietary NVIDIA drivers to be cumbersome—in fact, if not done properly it can be catastrophic. Although a how-to at <https://forums.fedoraproject.org/showpost.php?p=1114769&postcount=1> sums it up nicely in a step-by-step manner, I have been unable to go beyond a 1024x768-pixel resolution, as yet. So, if you can live without desktop effects, I'd recommend not installing the proprietary NVIDIA drivers at all.

## The Qt one

Fedora typically doesn't do much justice to KDE. However, now that KDE 4.3 has matured so much, I wanted to give the Fedora version a try separately on the laptop—that is, a fresh default install, uncheck GNOME and check KDE during package selection.

What I saw was a mouth-watering KDM theme, and an even better splash screen on my way to the desktop. Real great job by the artwork team! The desktop uses the same wallpaper as GNOME; otherwise, it doesn't offer any further customisation—there's a panel at the bottom with the usual icons, and a Folder View widget that points to my ~/Desktop folder, where the Trash and Home shortcuts sit. Also, the developers have tweaked the desktop right-click menu to add a Konsole shortcut (see Figure 7)—a very handy add-on.

Something odd that I noticed is the inclusion of the GNOME version of NetworkManager (Figure 8) instead of its KDE front-end (Figure 9). This beats me. Another problem I had was using the Crystal icons for all the Fedora GUI config apps (which are basically GTK toolkit-based). I'm sure creating a few icons that gel with the Oxygen icon set, if some of the replacements weren't already available in it set, wouldn't have been too time consuming.

On the upside, the default KDE install offers many more apps than its GNOME counterpart offers in Fedora—even some GTK/GNOME apps are

included. Now, Firefox, OpenOffice.org suite and the GIMP are really necessary, due to the lack of adequate Qt counterparts for these. But do you really need F-Spot when you have DigiKam; Rhythmbox when you have Amarok; Movie Player (Totem) when you have both Dragon Player and Kaffeine; Evolution when you have Kontact; or Transmission when you have a much more superior KTorrent already installed and available for use? Yes, there's more. Again, although K3b 1.x is available in the DVD, it's not installed. Instead, GNOME's Brasero is available. I'd have preferred the development version of the K3b2 installed instead.

Anyhow, I guess if Fedora also pays as much attention to KDE integration as it does to GNOME, KDE users won't have anything to complain about. Because the desktop otherwise feels just right—that is, w.r.t. performance and stability.

## The bottom line

Apart from the regular updated desktop, server, developer and IT admin tools, Constantine packs in (like its predecessors) a lot of features that are future-proof. There are enhancements right from the technology behind the boot splash screens to the general-purpose desktop, from security to virtualisation... Although I'm sure most of us still consider these newer technologies only-for-the-geeks, pretty soon we won't be able to do without them. Hey, even GNU/Linux was considered only-for-the-geeks once :)

As for everyday desktop use, if you're a GNOME user, I guess Fedora is a good choice and could very well compete with Ubuntu, et al. However, if you want KDE, openSUSE right now is the best choice (in my opinion).

P.S.: Well, John Constantine was a geek after all—and I mean that as a compliment. 

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